

taller than my entire fifth grade group. That's the perception people have — if you are tall and a little plump, you'll probably be good as a thrower," she says.

Although she hadn't organically chosen the event, Krishna would learn to love it. "I actually started with the shot put and I became fascinated by the way it left my hand and how I was able to make it fly with so much power. I liked how strong it made me feel. That's how I fell in love with track and field," she says.

It wasn't a wrong choice. Krishna would go on to compete and win medals in the shot put at the CBSE state level and break the CBSE national record. Eventually, with the intention of developing as an athlete, Krishna enrolled in the Tenvic Academy — the sports academy founded by former Indian cricketer Anil Kumble — in Guntur.

All in the family: Krishna's parents — Jayasankar Menon and Prasanna — have been national basketball captains.

It was there that Krishna would first meet Jamaican throws coach Michael Vassell. "Until then I'd only ever thrown the shot. But he was the first one who suggested that I had a wide enough wingspan and could throw the discus too. That's when I really started competing in the discus," she says.

That wasn't the only thing Vassell suggested to Krishna. "He was the first coach who suggested that I could consider applying for a sports scholarship to compete in the NCAA. That was the first time I learned that it was even a possibility — that I could study in the USA. That was when the dream first came to me," says Krishna.

Jamaican journey

That dream persisted even after Tenvic shut down during the pandemic, and Krishna returned to Chennai. "At that time I was really desperate to compete in the NCAA, but I wasn't sure how that would happen. And then coach Vassell

suggested I come and compete for some time in Jamaica," she says. Krishna's parents had taken their time to agree to her training in Guntur. Jamaica was all the way across the world. But Krishna was adamant. It was a decision that changed her life.

"Going to Jamaica gave me the kind of exposure I needed to make the move to the NCAA. Many US coaches, because of the proximity and the reputation of Jamaican track and field, are interested in working with Jamaican athletes. A lot of coaches come there personally to recruit athletes," she says.

It wasn't that there were no challenges. "Jamaica took some getting used to. I was an 18-year-old Indian girl. Jamaica is a beautiful country that I consider my second home, but there is the safety aspect I couldn't ignore. I was staying with coach Vassell at his home, and I'd travel an hour by public bus every day to go to school and train.

"As a kid in India, I was always pampered, and my parents were

